

OCS-022 — Constitutional Explanation

Status: Foundational

Authority: Constitutional

Depends on:

- OCS-000 through OCS-021
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Purpose

This specification defines the constitutional role of Explanation.

Explanation is the primary mechanism through which Understanding becomes communicable, testable, and improvable.

Observations without explanation remain isolated.

Knowledge without explanation cannot be transferred.

Understanding without explanation cannot become constitutional.

Every constitutional construct claiming Understanding SHALL provide an Explanation.

1. Definition

A Constitutional Explanation is a structured account describing why constitutional understanding currently takes its present form.

An Explanation SHALL preserve:

Meaning

Context

Evidence

Reasoning

History

Known uncertainty

Explanation SHALL remain independently reconstructable.

2. Purpose

The purpose of an Explanation is not persuasion.

The purpose is constitutional transparency.

An Explanation SHALL allow independent participants to understand:

What is believed.

Why it is believed.

How it became believed.

What could change that belief.

3. Components

Every Constitutional Explanation SHALL include:

Question

Observations

Interpretations

Supporting Evidence

Reasoning

Assumptions

Known Limitations

Remaining Uncertainty

Historical Context

Removal of any component SHALL reduce explanatory completeness.

4. Explanatory Scope

Every Explanation SHALL declare its intended scope.

Possible scopes include:

Local

Experimental

Operational

Canonical

Historical

Predictive

No Explanation SHALL silently exceed its declared scope.

5. Explanatory Dependencies

Every Explanation SHALL expose the constitutional constructs upon which it depends.

Dependencies MAY include:

Questions

Experiments

Observations

Evidence

Canonical Definitions

Previous Explanations

Dependencies SHALL remain explicit.

6. Explanatory Power

The constitutional quality of an Explanation SHALL be evaluated by its ability to:

Explain existing observations.

Predict future observations.

Remain internally coherent.

Reduce ambiguity.

Support future investigation.

Explanatory elegance SHALL never replace explanatory adequacy.

7. Competing Explanations

Multiple Explanations MAY coexist.

Competing Explanations SHALL remain constitutional citizens.

Competition SHALL occur through:

Evidence

Reasoning

Prediction

Methodological integrity

Competition SHALL NOT occur through authority.

8. Explanatory Failure

Failure of an Explanation SHALL constitute constitutional learning.

Failed Explanations SHALL preserve:

Historical context.

Original assumptions.

Supporting evidence.

Reason for failure.

Failure SHALL remain permanently attributable.

9. Explanatory Evolution

Explanations MAY evolve.

Evolution SHALL preserve:

Historical lineage.

Previous versions.

Reasons for revision.

Evidence supporting revision.

Evolution SHALL improve Understanding.

Not erase history.

10. Explanatory Economy

An Explanation SHOULD avoid unnecessary complexity.

Complexity SHALL exist only when constitutionally necessary.

Reduction of complexity SHALL NOT reduce explanatory capability.

11. Explanatory Responsibility

Every Explanation SHALL distinguish between:

Observed.

Inferred.

Assumed.

Predicted.

Unknown.

These distinctions SHALL remain explicit.

12. Explanatory Transparency

Independent investigators SHALL be capable of reconstructing the reasoning process that produced an Explanation.

Hidden reasoning SHALL constitute constitutional incompleteness.

13. Explanatory Continuity

Every Explanation SHALL remain connected to:

Earlier Explanations.

Current Understanding.

Future Revisions.

Explanation SHALL participate in constitutional continuity.

14. Constitutional Explanation Test

A Constitutional Explanation satisfies this specification when an independent investigator can answer:

What does this explain?

What evidence supports it?

What assumptions does it rely upon?

What remains unexplained?

How could it be challenged?

How could it improve?

If any question cannot be answered,

the Explanation is constitutionally incomplete.

Conformance

An implementation conforms to this specification when constitutional explanations remain reconstructable, challengeable, historically continuous, and semantically equivalent across independent implementations.

Constitutional Principle

Understanding becomes constitutional only when it can be explained.

Explanation transforms private insight into shared knowledge.

The strength of a discipline is therefore measured not by how many conclusions it contains,

but by how clearly every conclusion explains itself.

End of Specification OCS-022